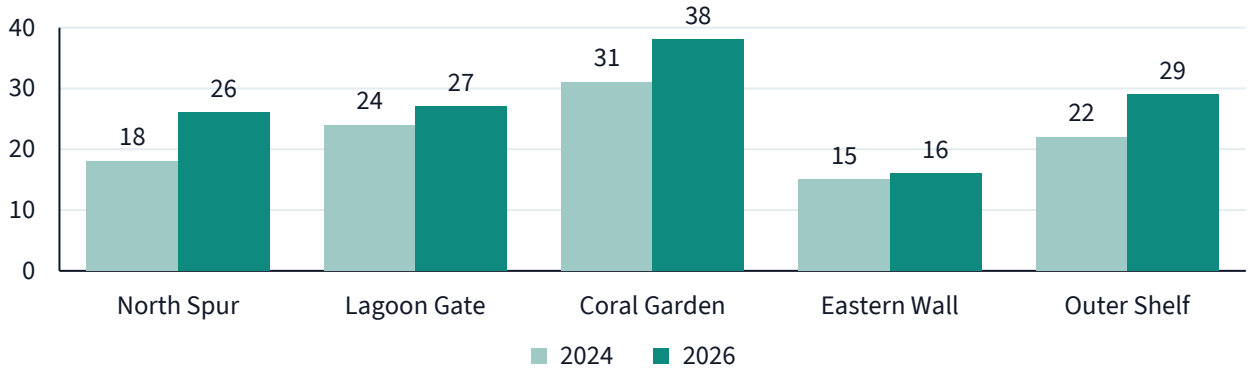
FIELD REPORT · NOVEMBER 2026

The reef is recovering, unevenly

Two years after the 2024 bleaching event, live coral cover has risen at four of our five monitored sites. The gains are real, but they are concentrated where the water stayed coolest.

Across 212 survey dives between March and September, divers recorded an average gain of **5.2 percentage points** in live coral cover. The Coral Garden, sheltered by the northern headland, recovered fastest; the Eastern Wall, exposed to the warm boundary current, has barely moved.[1]

Live coral cover by site



Site	Depth	2024	2026	Change
North Spur	6–9 m	18%	26%	+8
Lagoon Gate	3–5 m	24%	27%	+3
Coral Garden	4–7 m	31%	38%	+7
Eastern Wall	10–14 m	15%	16%	+1
Outer Shelf	8–12 m	22%	29%	+7

Recommendation. Concentrate the 2027 restoration budget on the Eastern Wall, where natural recovery has stalled, and extend temperature logging to the boundary current so that the next warm spell is seen weeks in advance.

1 Cover is estimated from 50-metre photo transects at fixed stations, with each image scored at 100 random points.